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INDIAN COUNCIL OF SOCIAL SCIENCE RESEARCH
Research Projects Division

Format for Major and Minor Research Proposal -(2025-26)

Applicants must adhere to the word limit specified in each section. Deviation from the ICSSR research proposal format will result in the rejection of the application.

Application number **(copy from your online application)**	
Broad Research Domains as per ICSSR list (See Point No. 1.2 of the Guidelines)	**Political Science**
Priority Areas	**Women and Politics**
Title of the Research Proposal (same as in the online application)	**From Symbolic Presence to Substantive Power: A Case Study on Women Leaders in Andhra Pradesh's Governance.** This

1. **Abstract**
   Up to 300 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This research studies the progress of the Women's participation in Andhra Pradesh examining their journey from token representation to exercising real authority in governance structures. Despite constitutional amendments 73rd and 74th secured reservations, by framing a solid policy framework for women's presence in politics, it is observed a significant gap continue between women's presence in elected positions and their ability to execute their real authority. This research focusses on the realities of women elected across Andhra Pradesh for different governance levels such as Panchayath Raj Offices, Urban Municipalities, the State Assembly and even Parliament.

It is well known fact as per the recent state data, that women over 55% in Andhra Pradesh occupied Sarpanch positions, around 52% of the seats in Urban Local Bodies are filled by them, along with 14 women MLAs and 2 Members of Parliament. As per this data, it is observed that the number of women presences is increased, but the challenges they have been facing related their administrative tasks, prevailing gender norms and hierarchical political arrangements are completely hidden.

Hence, this study is purposed to address all levels of governance such as **Sarpanches, MPTCs, ZPTCS, Ward Members - Local Bodies, Municipal Councillors, and Chairpersons - Urban Bodies, MLAs - State Legislators and MPs - National Representatives.** Through Case studies interviews, focused group discussions and document analysis, a qualitative field approach will be used to survey how women enhanced their administrative competence, interact with the officials, formulate welfare initiatives, negotiate authority and mobilise community networks.

Eventually, this work is aimed to document evidence-based insights that will help strengthen gender-responsive governance. By documenting how representation converts to authority, we contribute insights that can support women's progress from their symbolic participation to sustained, substantive leadership throughout Andhra Pradesh.

2. Introduction, Theoretical Framework and Scope of the Proposed Research

Up to 500 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Women leaders in Andhra Pradesh face a complex challenge: moving beyond symbolic representation toward genuine authority across local, state, and national governance. The 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments institutionalized reservations, establishing a robust policy foundation for inclusion. However, substantial gaps persist between numerical representation and meaningful empowerment. Our research investigates the lived realities of women elected across different governance tiers.

Recent state statistics paint an interesting picture. Women now hold over 55% of Sarpanch positions and more than 52% of seats in Urban Local Bodies. The 2024 State Assembly includes 14 women MLAs, while two women represent the state in Parliament. These figures indicate increasing visibility. Yet they conceal ongoing struggles related to administrative responsibilities, gendered expectations, and entrenched political hierarchies.

Our study encompasses the full governance spectrum. At the local level, we examine Sarpanches, MPTCs, ZPTCs, and ward members. Urban governance includes Municipal Councillors and Chairpersons. We also investigate State Legislators, National Representatives, and the crucial role of Self-Help Groups - SHGs.

The research employs qualitative, field-based methods. We conduct case studies, in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, and systematic document analysis. This approach allows us to understand how women build administrative competence, engage with bureaucrats and officials, shape welfare initiatives, negotiate power dynamics, and mobilize community networks.

Several theoretical frameworks guide our analysis. Feminist institutionalism helps us understand how gendered norms shape political institutions. The concept of gendered citizenship illuminates how women claim rights and responsibilities. Theories of everyday governance reveal how authority functions in practice, beyond formal structures.

Andhra Pradesh presents a particularly rich context. The state has an extensive SHG ecosystem with over 1.15 crore members. These groups provide platforms for collective action, financial access, and civic engagement. Many women use SHG experience as a stepping stone toward electoral participation. The state's village and ward secretariat system has restructured local administration, with nearly half of functionaries being women.

The 2024 Assembly elections demonstrate evolving patterns. Women elected as MLAs come from diverse districts across the state. Field observations suggest many begin with support from male relatives or party structures. However, they progressively assume independent control, particularly over welfare monitoring, grievance redressal, and scheme implementation. Prior SHG or community leadership experience appears especially valuable.

We structure our analysis around three interconnected layers. First, institutional negotiation: examining how women operate within Panchayats, Municipalities, the Assembly, and Parliament while navigating caste relations, party networks, and patronage systems. Second, grassroots empowerment: exploring how SHG membership, credit access, financial literacy, and livelihood programs build autonomy and legitimacy. Third, governance outcomes: assessing whether women's leadership improves service delivery, fund utilization, transparency, and citizen engagement.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Our methodology involves 60-70 detailed interviews and 25-30 focus group discussions. We observe formal proceedings and review relevant documents. By tracking women's experiences across these analytical layers, we examine how representation becomes authority. We investigate how women progress from symbolic presence to substantive power in shaping political, administrative, and social outcomes.

3. Review of Key Research Works for the Proposed Research

Up to 600 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Research on women's leadership in India has evolved considerably. Early work focused primarily on counting seats and documenting representation. More recent scholarship analyzes how women actually exercise authority, negotiate decision-making processes, and influence governance outcomes. Andhra Pradesh, given its extensive SHG network, active Panchayati Raj institutions, and growing presence of women across elected offices, features prominently in this evolving body of work.

We can identify five interrelated themes in the existing literature:

1. **Representation versus Authority:** Reservations expand political access, but scholars like Jayal (2006) emphasize that quotas increase numerical representation without automatically conferring decision-making power. Structural and social barriers persist. National assessments from the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2023) similarly document the gap between holding office and exercising genuine authority.

2. **Proxy Leadership and Transition to Autonomy:** Male relatives or party operatives frequently guide administrative work initially on behalf of elected women. Research by Banerjee & Kazi, along with work by Krishnaraj, documents this pattern. However, state-level evaluations in Andhra Pradesh reveal a more dynamic picture. Studies by SERP Andhra Pradesh (2022-23) show that institutional support, capacity-building programs, and community networks enable many women to progressively acquire real administrative control.

3. **Policy Priorities and Measurable Outcomes:** Women's leadership shifts governance priorities. Chattopadhyay & Duflo's influential 2004 study in Econometrica demonstrated that women allocate more resources toward water, sanitation, and education, yielding measurable improvements. Research specific to Andhra Pradesh reports similar findings, with substantive engagement in NREGS monitoring, social audits, housing allocation, and health initiatives.

4. **Aspirations, Role Models, and Upward Mobility:** Beaman et al. (2012), Writing in Science, showed that visible female leaders raise political aspirations among girls and young women. This contributes to improved educational outcomes and expands the pool of future leaders. In Andhra Pradesh, SHG-led confidence-building serves as a preparatory stage for higher electoral roles.

5. **Intersectional Constraints and Institutional Support:** Rao & Katju (2017) in the Journal of South Asian Development examine how caste, class, and party networks determine which women benefit from formal inclusion. Targeted capacity-building interventions enhance administrative competence. Yet similar support remains uneven at higher legislative levels, as documented by both the Ministry of Panchayati Raj in 2023 and SERP - 2022-23.

Together, these scholarly contributions establish several key points. First, institutional mechanisms like SHG networks and training programs materially enable women to convert representation into authority. Second, persistent social and political inequalities constrain upward mobility. The present study builds on this foundation by analyzing how these dynamics unfold across Andhra Pradesh's governance structures.

Works Cited:

- Chattopadhyay, R., & Duflo, E. (2004). Women as Policy Makers: Evidence from a Randomized Policy Experiment in India. Econometrica, 72(5), 1409-1443.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

- Jayal, N. G. (2006). Engendering Local Democracy: The Impact of Quotas for Women in India's Panchayats. Democratization, 13(1), 15–35.
- Beaman, L., Duflo, E., Pande, R., & Topalova, P. (2012). Female Leadership Raises Aspirations and Educational Attainment for Girls. Science, 335(6068), 582-586.
- Rao, A., & Katju, M. (2017). Gender, Caste and Electoral Politics in Andhra Pradesh. Journal of South Asian Development, 12(3), 323-342.
- Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Government of India. (2023). Status of Women in Panchayati Raj Institutions.
- SERP Andhra Pradesh. (2022–23). Annual Report 2022-23.

4. Identification of Research Gap

Up to 300 words

Several critical gaps exist in our understanding of how women in Andhra Pradesh assume leadership roles, make decisions, and navigate political structures across governance levels. Women are present in all 29 districts, yet we lack sufficient analysis of how their opportunities, constraints, and leadership patterns vary as they move from Panchayati Raj Institutions to municipal bodies, the State Assembly, and Parliament.

Most existing research concentrates on local governance, numerical representation, or isolated aspects of leadership. Studies document the role of reservations, SHG support, and training in enhancing visibility and administrative skills at the Panchayat level. They also reveal persistence of proxy leadership, caste and class constraints, and limited influence in decision-making. However, few studies examine women's progression to higher offices, particularly in socio-economically diverse districts encompassing tribal areas, coastal regions, and Rayalaseema.

We also have limited understanding of how women's priorities, decision-making approaches, and leadership styles evolve with increasing responsibilities. How do they sustain influence while negotiating institutional and party structures at higher levels? Research on SC/ST women rarely extends beyond Panchayats. This leaves significant gaps regarding their roles in state and national politics, including constituencies such as Araku, Rampachodavaram, Prathipadu, and Sullurpeta.

Furthermore, the role of digital platforms, social media, and other emerging tools in supporting or challenging women leaders remains underexplored. Most studies focus on local governance, overlooking the distinct pressures, strategies, and opportunities faced by women MLAs and MPs in contemporary political environments.

Our research addresses these gaps by examining leadership trajectories across all governance levels, analyzing how women convert representation into authority in varied socio-economic contexts, and investigating the tools and networks that support their progression from symbolic presence to substantive power.

5. Objectives of the Proposed Research

Up to 200 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This research develops an evidence-based understanding of how women in Andhra Pradesh move from elected positions to substantive leadership. Our objectives reflect recent governance reforms and shifts in political participation:

1. We examine the social conditions, motivations, and institutional factors influencing women's entry into governance across levels in Andhra Pradesh. This includes ZPTCs, Municipal Chairpersons, Municipal Commissioners, MLAs, and MPs, with particular attention to reservations, SHG networks, and expanding representation.

2. We document the governance practices of women leaders, their planning, budgeting, welfare delivery monitoring, coordination with ward and village secretariats, and community engagement. This occurs particularly in the context of expanded responsibilities following 2020 reforms.

3. We assess institutional, social, and political factors that support or limit women's functioning. These include caste dynamics, party networks, bureaucratic cooperation, digital platforms, and capacity-building access.

4. We trace the shift from assisted or proxy roles to independent decision-making. This involves analyzing strategies women adopt, confidence-building processes they rely on, and leadership styles that help them gain authority and public recognition.

5. We generate policy-relevant insights to strengthen gender-responsive governance in Andhra Pradesh. This includes identifying training needs, institutional reforms, and support mechanisms that promote substantive leadership across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban contexts.

6. Major Research Questions and, If Applicable Hypotheses

Up to 200 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This work addresses several questions about women's entry, participation, and leadership in Andhra Pradesh's governance:

1. What motivates women to contest local elections? How do family, community, and political factors influence their entry?
2. How do elected women engage in governance functions planning, budgeting, welfare delivery, and community mobilization?
3. What institutional, social, and cultural barriers limit their autonomy in Panchayati Raj Institutions and Urban Local Bodies?
4. Which enabling factors enhance women's confidence and authority? This includes training, mentorship, administrative support, and community networks.
5. How do women negotiate power and transition from symbolic roles to substantive leadership across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban contexts?
6. How do caste, local institutions, and political environments shape variations in leadership experiences?

Hypotheses

- **H1:** Women with access to training, mentorship, and administrative support display higher participation and influence in governance.
- **H2:** Social norms, caste relations, and political networks significantly affect women's autonomy and decision-making power.

7. **Proposed Methodology for the Research Work**
   Including, if applicable, justification of research sites, sampling, sample size, data collection methods, data analysis methods.
   Up to 500 words

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This study adopts a qualitative, field-based approach to examine how women in Andhra Pradesh move from occupying elected positions to exercising meaningful leadership across local, state, and national governance levels. Our methodology captures diverse experiences across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban settings, reflecting the state's social, cultural, and administrative diversity.

Research Sites and Justification

We conduct research across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban areas of Andhra Pradesh. Districts with significant Scheduled Tribe and Scheduled Caste populations are included to understand how intersecting social identities influence leadership opportunities and constraints.

Rural sites focus on Panchayati Raj Institutions, where women engage with community development issues and local administration. Semi-urban areas undergoing demographic and administrative transitions reveal adaptive challenges women face in evolving local bodies. Urban sites, particularly municipal corporations, provide insights into women's engagement with formal bureaucratic structures and politically complex environments. This selection enables meaningful comparison across settings and supports our objective of identifying context-specific leadership pathways.

Sampling and Sample Size

We employ purposive sampling to identify women representatives across governance tiers. The study includes Sarpanches, Ward Members, Women in Tribal Local Bodies, and Elected Representatives in Municipalities. Additional stakeholders Local Officials, Community Leaders, and Frontline Workers provide supplementary perspectives.

We target a sample of 40-50 women, ensuring diversity in caste, political affiliation, age, education, and length of tenure. This sample size achieves depth, saturation, and comparison across governance contexts.

Data Collection Methods

Multiple qualitative tools generate comprehensive and reliable data. The Co-Project Director, a faculty member in Computer Science and Engineering, strengthens the technical process:

- **In-depth Interviews:** Semi-structured interviews with women leaders capture motivations, administrative responsibilities, constraints, decision-making practices, and interactions with officials, communities, and political actors.
- **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs):** FGDs with community members, local officials, and women's groups assess perceptions of women's leadership, public trust, and community mobilization.
- **Observation:** Non-participant observation of Gram Sabha meetings, municipal council sessions, public hearings, and field inspections documents real-time leadership practices and interactions.
- **Document Analysis:** We review official documents annual plans, budgets, meeting minutes, circulars, and social audit records to triangulate field data and understand formal decision-making processes.

Data Analysis

We analyze data thematically. Interview and FGD transcripts are coded to identify recurring themes related to barriers, enabling factors, strategies, and leadership outcomes.

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Observational notes and documentary evidence are integrated to strengthen interpretation. Comparative analysis across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban sites highlights variations in women's experiences. Analytical insights draw on frameworks from feminist institutionalism, gendered citizenship, and everyday governance to understand how women exercise agency within structural constraints.

Ethical Considerations

We obtain informed consent from all participants. Confidentiality and anonymity are strictly maintained. Respectful and culturally sensitive interactions are ensured, particularly with women from marginalized communities. The study follows ethical guidelines for field-based social research, safeguarding participants' rights and dignity throughout the research process.

8. **Innovation/Path-Breaking Aspects of the Proposed Research**
   Up to 150 to 200 words

This study introduces several innovative elements in examining women's leadership in Andhra Pradesh.

At first, it adopts a comprehensive, context-sensitive approach covering rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban local bodies. This enables comparative analysis of leadership pathways across diverse social and institutional settings.

Secondly, it emphasizes women's everyday governance practices rather than conventional indicators like numerical representation. By integrating in-depth interviews, FGDs, observation, and document review, the study captures decision-making strategies, official interactions, and gradual assertion of authority aspects often overlooked in existing literature.

At this phase, it highlights the transition from symbolic representation to substantive leadership, tracing how women build administrative knowledge, negotiation skills, and community recognition over time.

Finally, by drawing on feminist institutionalism, gendered citizenship, and everyday governance frameworks, the study offers policy-relevant findings to guide training programs, institutional reforms, and inclusive governance strategies. The insights may inform approaches beyond Andhra Pradesh, contributing to broader policy and research discourses on women's political leadership.

9. **Expected Output**
   Journal publication, books, edited books, policy papers, dataset etc. Include publication timelines and places of publication.
   Up to 300 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

The research generates several scholarly and policy-oriented outputs, advancing the study of women's leadership in local governance in Andhra Pradesh and contributing to broader debates on gender-responsive governance.

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles:
We prepare at least two articles based on field findings for high-impact journals in political science, gender studies, and public administration, such as Economic and Political Weekly - EPW, Journal of Development Studies, and Indian Journal of Gender Studies.

Timeline: First article within 12 months of data collection; second article within 18 months.
Comprehensive Research Report:
A detailed report presents research design, methodology, field findings, and policy recommendations, suitable for publication with academic publishers or dissemination through research institutes.

Timeline: Completion within 24 months of starting fieldwork.
Edited Volume or Policy Brief:
An edited volume or policy brief highlights governance challenges, best practices, and recommendations for capacity-building programs for women leaders. We disseminate this through government departments, think tanks, and policy forums.

Timeline: 20–22 months.
Research Dataset:
A systematically compiled qualitative dataset, including anonymized interview transcripts, observational notes, and contextual data, is prepared following ICSSR data-sharing guidelines. This serves as a resource for future research and policymaking.

Timeline: 18–20 months.
Conference Presentations:
Preliminary and final findings are presented at national and international conferences on governance, development, and gender studies, ensuring scholarly visibility and engagement with policymakers.

Through these peer-reviewed articles, a detailed research report, policy briefs, a structured dataset, and conference presentations, the study aims to contribute both to academic knowledge and practical governance reforms. We offer evidence-based guidance to strengthen women's meaningful participation in local decision-making across Andhra Pradesh.

10. Relevance of the Proposed Research for Policy

Up to 200 words.

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

This study holds high relevance for policymaking and governance reforms in Andhra Pradesh and across India. By examining women's leadership trajectories, decision-making practices, and everyday governance strategies, the research offers evidence-based insights into factors that support or limit effective participation of women in Panchayati Raj Institutions - PRIs and Urban Local Bodies - ULBs.

The findings can guide capacity-building programs by highlighting which forms of training, mentorship, and administrative support most effectively strengthen women's competence, confidence, and engagement in governance. They can also inform institutional reforms aimed at creating governance processes that encourage women's involvement in planning, budgeting, welfare delivery, infrastructure management, and community mobilization.
Additionally, the study's attention to social and political factors caste, class, and local governance culture provides clear understanding of context-specific barriers and enabling conditions. Evidence from rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban areas helps design policies that are inclusive, gender-sensitive, and responsive to local needs.

Overall, the research provides a practical basis for enhancing women's participation and influence in local governance, supporting constitutional provisions for gender equality, and promoting more accountable, participatory, and equitable decision-making at the grassroots level.

11. Relevance of the Proposed Research for Society
Up to 200 words

This study holds significant societal relevance by illuminating how women in Andhra Pradesh move from symbolic representation to meaningful participation and leadership in local governance. By examining everyday governance practices, decision-making processes, and community engagement, the research highlights mechanisms through which women exercise influence, improve public service delivery, and address local developmental needs.

The findings can empower communities by demonstrating the potential of women leaders to effect change in education, health, sanitation, and infrastructure, fostering more inclusive and responsive governance. Insights into enabling factors SHG networks, mentorship, and institutional support offer pathways for enhancing women's leadership across diverse social and cultural contexts.

Additionally, by documenting challenges women face, including caste dynamics, political networks, and structural constraints, the study promotes greater awareness of social inequalities and encourages strategies for equitable participation.

It contributes to broader societal goals of gender equality, social justice, and community empowerment. The research demonstrates how effective female leadership at local, state, and national levels can strengthen democratic practices, improve accountability, and inspire future generations to participate in governance.

12. Milestones for Each Quarter of the Proposed Research

The application must be submitted online only. Mentioning the name of the Project Director, Co-Project Directors, or the affiliating University/Institution anywhere in the research proposal will result in disqualification.

Timeline	Milestones / Activities	Deliverables
6 months	Identification of research sites and selection of participants; development of interview guides and data collection instruments; initial literature review and contextual study.	Research plan, finalized tools for fieldwork, preliminary site reports.
12 months	Fieldwork: Conducting in-depth interviews, focus group discussions, and non-participant observation across rural, tribal, semi-urban, and urban sites. collection of documents and records.	Complete field notes, interview transcripts, observational data, and preliminary findings summaries.
18 months	Data analysis: Thematic coding of qualitative data, cross-context comparison, validation through triangulation; preparation of draft research outputs including articles and policy briefs. analysis reports.	Thematically coded datasets, draft research articles, preliminary policy recommendations, and contextual
24 months	Completion of final data analysis; preparation of comprehensive research report; dissemination of findings through publications, policy briefs, and conference presentations; submission of final deliverables	Final research report, peer-reviewed journal articles, policy briefs, conference presentations, and structured research dataset compliant with ICSSR guidelines.

13. Budget

Total Grant expected under the scheme (In Rs.)	Rs. 21,00,000/-
Number & Names of the States your study covers (if any):	No. of States: 01 Andhra Pradesh

14. Proposed Budget of the Proposed Research, Including Justification (See Point No. 6.3 of the Guidelines)

Heads of Expenditure	Number	Months	Rate	Amount
1. Research Staff: Full time/part time/ Hired services (See Point No. 6.4 of the Guidelines)				
(a) Research Associate	1	18		
(b) Research Assistant	1	18		
(c) Field Investigator	2	12		
2. Field work				
3. Research Equipment and study material (Computer, Printer etc.)				
4. Contingency				
Total				

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5. Workshop/ Seminar/Publication *This will be determined by the ICSSR based on the project requirements. The allocation for publication will be retained by the ICSSR for publication of the final report if deemed to be of high quality by the experts appointed by the ICSSR				
Grand Total Affiliating Institutional Overhead Charges at 10% over and above on the awarded grant of the project, subject to a maximum limit of Rs.2, 00,000/- for major and minor projects, will be released by the ICSSR after the successful completion of the project.				

15. Budget Justification for Different Heads

1. Research Staff

The research team is needed for effective accomplishment of this study. A Research Associate will be appointed at full-time to help ad support the entire research work like field work, and assess data. A Research Assistant will offer support in literature review, data entry, and preliminary analysis. As the work demands, two field Investigators will be appointed on a contractual basis to pool up the primary data from district and local governance bodies across the state. Remunerations are proposed in accordance with the ICSSR norms, to ensure constant association and quality research output over 18 months.

2. Field work

One of the important components of the work is Field work - including visits to many districts for interviews, focus group discussions and case studies with the women leaders across the state governance. The budget covers travel, local transport, accommodation and daily allowance for the research team and field investigators. The proposed allocation makes sures a detailed and systematic data collection while following to the ethical research standards.

3. Equipment and material

The study needs key equipment like computers, printers, recording devices, stationery and software for managing the entire data collection, processing and storage. This equipment and material will help to document and analyse the research finding authentically. The allocation is done in accordance with the ICSSR standards to provide high-quality, field based social science research.

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